

Kalaupapa National Historical Park Guidelines for the Management of Coconut Trees

Coconut trees (*Cocos nucifera*) are a significant palm throughout Hawaii and tropical regions around the world. These palms can reach over 100' in height and may live over 100 years. They regularly shed coconuts and large fronds, which may expose people and property to injury and damage. To minimize this risk, coconuts and fronds must be regularly removed prior to their fall. In certain instances, coconut trees may possess structural defects that increase the risk of failure of a portion or all of the tree.

This brochure is designed to provide guidance for staff and tree workers in the proper pruning and general assessment of coconut trees. When caring for coconut trees, the safety of people and property is our greatest priority.

Pruning is recommended within developed areas to manage the hazards of falling coconuts and fronds and to minimize risk to persons and property within the fall zone.

In order to ensure safe, healthy and attractive palms that can achieve a maximum life-span within a specific site, we recommend that the tree worker who is pruning the tree:

1. Report abnormal conditions in the crown, trunk, or base of the tree.
2. Remove yellow/brown fronds, fruit, flowers, seedpods and fruit stalks carefully without damaging the trunk or fronds that are to be retained.
3. Remove lower fronds where any part of the frond hangs below a horizontal plane to avoid stressing due to over trimming (see Figure 1).
4. Not remove live, healthy fronds above horizontal except where encroaching on utilities or structures (see Figure 2).
5. Not embed the cutting tool into the trunk or fronds that will remain on the coconut tree.
6. Traditional tree climbing methods have historically been used to reach these tall trees (using spikes to maintain grips with hands and feet).
7. Trimming tools will be disinfected between trees using flame or other sterilization techniques in the event the coconut trees have disease.

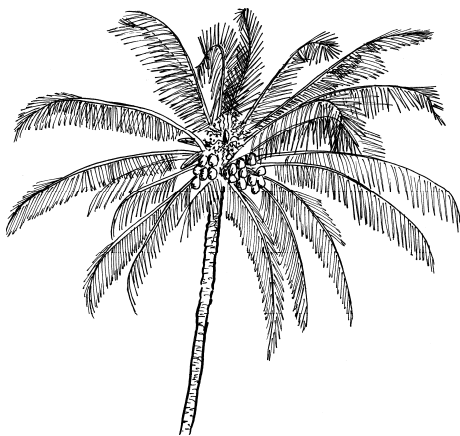


Figure 1

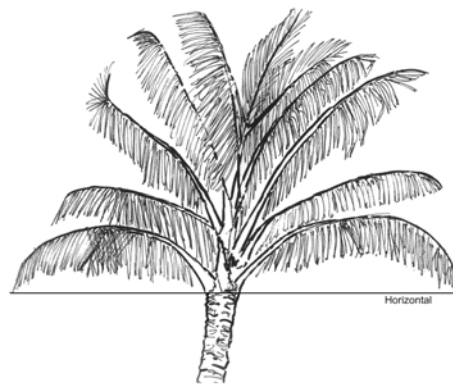


Figure 2